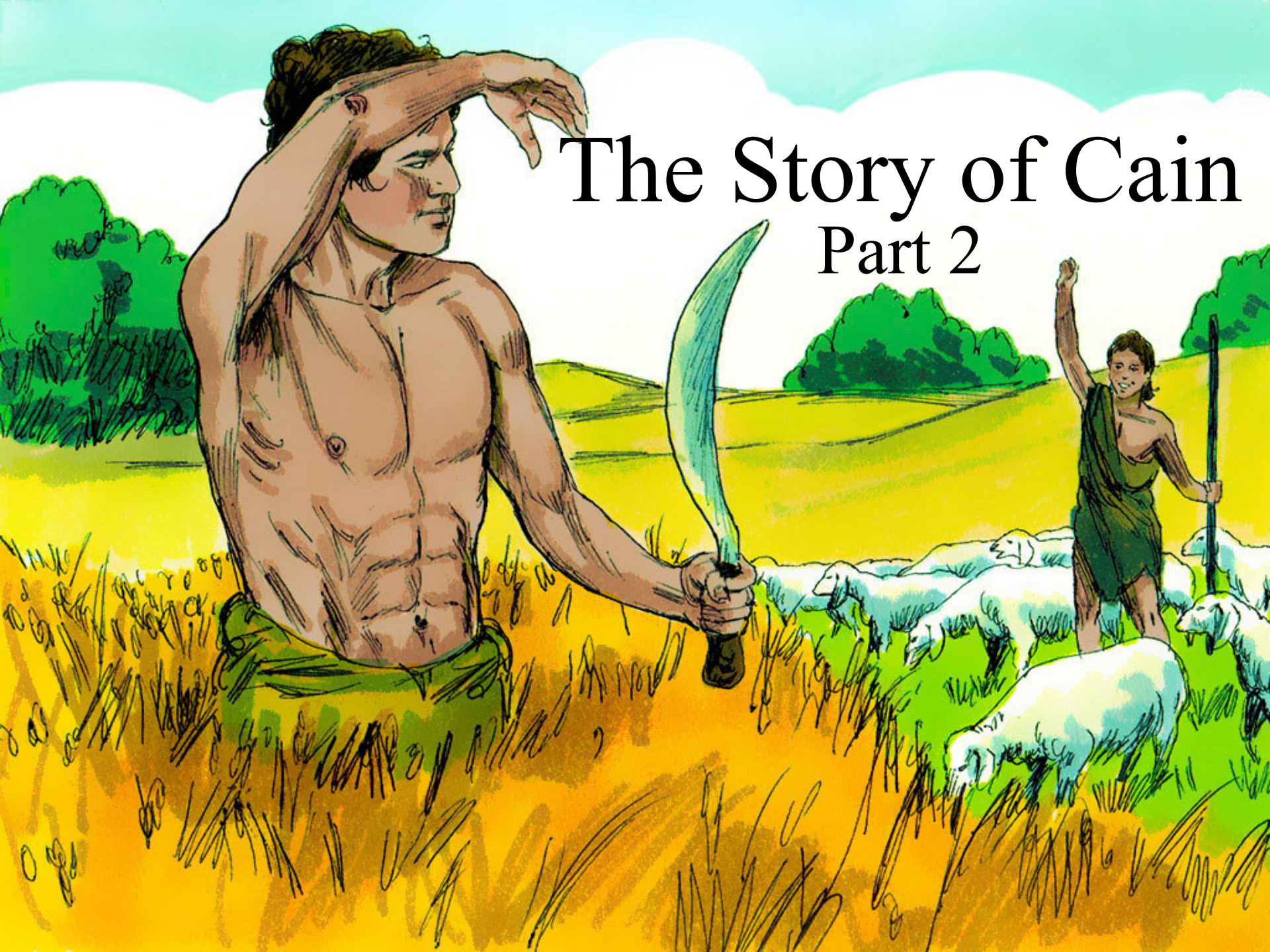

The Story of Cain
Part 2

“You will rule over it.”

A Paraphrase

“Why are you angry?
And why is your face fallen?
If you do well, won’t you be happy and content?
But if you don’t do well, sin is lying at the door,
waiting to get you.
But it’s your decision.”

And Cain spoke to Abel, his brother.
And it happened when they were in the field.
Cain rose up against Abel, his brother.
And he killed him.

- Quick narrative comments to move to second encounter between God and Cain

And the Lord said to Cain:
"Where is Abel, your brother."

And he said:
"I don't know. Am I my brother's keeper?"

And he said:
"What have you done?!
The voice of the blood of your brother is crying to me from the ground.
And now . . .
Cursed are you from the ground that opened its mouth to take the blood of your brother from your hand.
Though you serve the ground, it will not again give its strength to you.
A roamer and wanderer you will be on the earth.

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First Question

- God's question
  - God asks a probing question *(as with Adam)*
    - *"Where are you?"*
    - *"Where is your brother?"*
  - God speaks to Cain's heart
- Cain's Response
  - Denies responsibility for another *(unity in plurality)*
  - Even his own close relative *(brother)*
  - Self-condemning response
    - Not "Am I *Abel's* keeper?"
    - but "Am I *my brother's* keeper?"

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Heart Leads to Action

- God initially counseled Cain
  - Don’t be angry
  - Do right and you’ll be happy
- Cain’s Response
  - Ignored God’s counsel
  - Killed his brother
  - Denies any responsibility

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Judgment

- Further estrangement from the ground
  - Creation:
    - the ground produces food
  - Eden:
    - trees produce food apart from work
  - Banishment
    - food from the cursed ground
    - hard work to produce food
    - ground to produce thorns *(good soil with weeds)*
  - Cain:
    - ground will not produce its strength *(bad soil)*
    - Cain now forced to wander the earth *(in search of food?)*

And Cain said to the Lord:

"My punishment is too great to bear.
Behold, you have banished me this day from upon the face of the ground.
And from your face I will be hidden.
And I will be a roamer and wanderer on the earth.
And it will be that all who find me will kill me."

And the Lord said to him:

"Therefore, all who kill Cain it will be avenged seven times."

And the Lord set a sign on Cain, to not smite him, all who find him.
And Cain went out from the face of the Lord.
And he dwelled in a land of wandering, east of Eden.

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- Unlike in Eden, Cain complains about his punishment.

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Exaggeration

- Point #1
  - Cain: “banished from the face of the ground”
  - God: “the ground will not give its strength”
- Point #2
  - Cain: “from your face I will be hidden”
  - God: <nothing>
- Note:
  - ***In both his sacrifice and punishment, Cain associates his working the ground with his relationship with God***

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Knowledge of Good and Bad

- Cain
  - Makes an assessment
  - Concern is for self-preservation
- God
  - Responds in grace
    - Protects Cain's vulnerability
    - Watches out for Cain's welfare

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- Again, humans withdrawing from God

Genre Change

- From story to a genealogy
- A genealogy with narrative insertions
- Genealogy of Cain
  - expressing what developed from him
  - what developed from . . .
    - continued “knowledge of good and bad”
    - further alienation between humans *(unity in plurality)*
    - further alienation from God

And Cain knew his wife.
And she became pregnant
And she bore Enoch.
And he was building a city,
And he called the name of the city
according to the name of his son, Enoch.

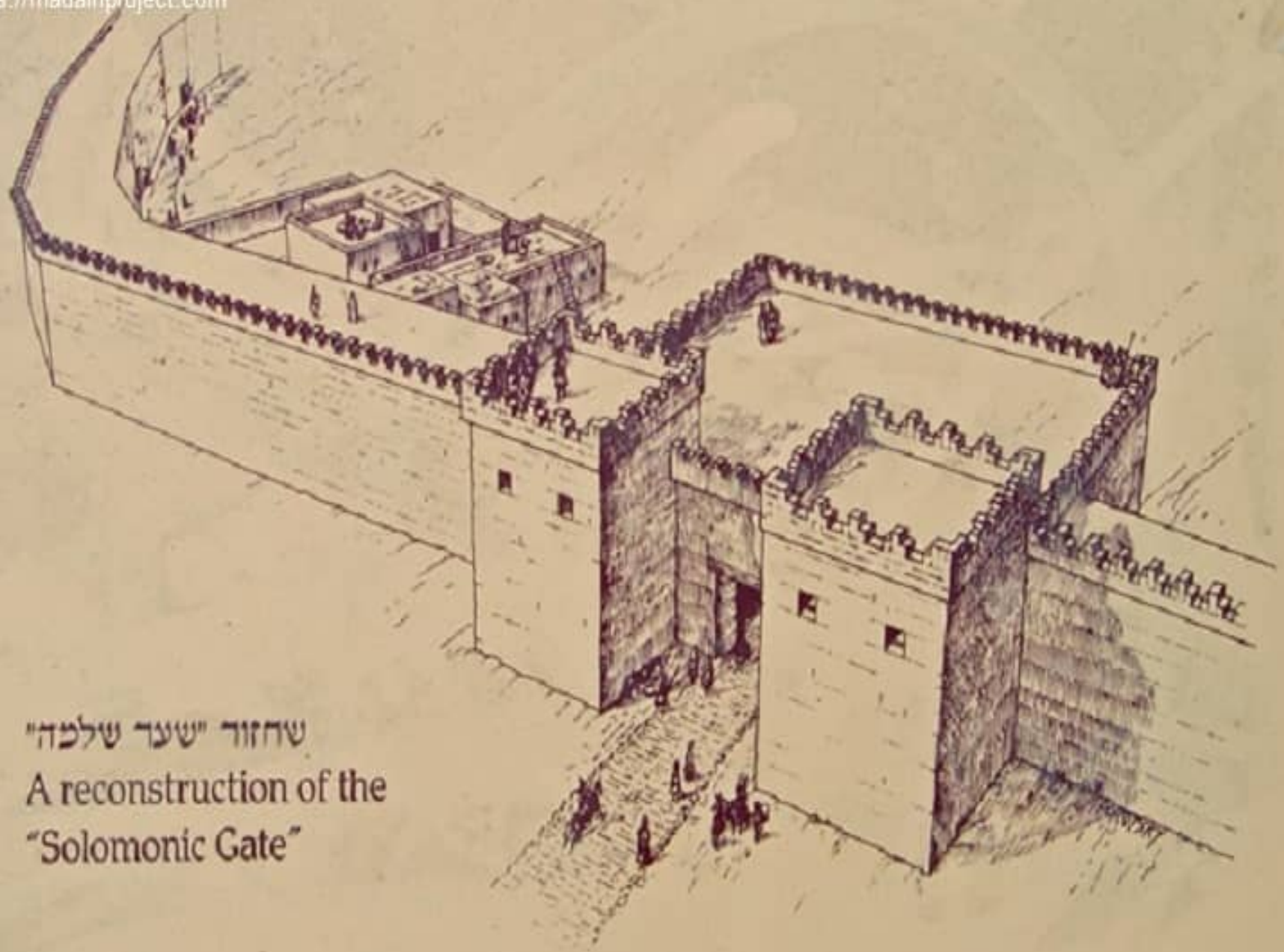
Enoch

- Background
  - Cain was cursed to be a wanderer
- Cain builds a city
  - in direct opposition to being a wanderer
    - his attempt to fight the judgment
    - his attempt to protect himself (the nature of ancient cities)

Cities

- Ancient Cities
  - walled, with gates

MadainProject
https://madainproject.com



שחזור "שער שלמה"

A reconstruction of the "Solomonic Gate"

Herod’s Gate

Cities

- Ancient Cities
  - walled, with gates
  - primarily for protection against attack
- Cain's is the First City
  - opposition to God's actions
  - self-preservation
- Second Biblical Occurrence
  - Nimrod *(Genesis 10)*
- Third Biblical Occurrence
  - Babel (*Genesis 11)*
  - Babylon, a biblical paradigm *(human strength, self-preservation, independnce)*
- New Jerusalem

Enoch

- Background
  - Cain was cursed to be a wanderer
- Cain builds a city
  - in direct opposition to being a wanderer
    - his attempt to fight the judgment
    - his attempt to protect himself (the nature of city's)
- Cain names the city after his son
  - celebrates his accomplishment ("Enoch"=celebration)
  - children are hope for future life
  - Cain's hope for life is his own efforts
    - further dependence upon works (like his sacrifice)

And to Enoch was born Irad.
And Irad begat Mekhuyael
And Mekhuyael begat Methushael
And Methushael begat Lamech.

And Lamech took two wives,
the name of one Adah,
and the name of the second Zillah.
And Adah bore Jabal.
He was the father of the dwellers of tents and cattle.
And the name of his brother, Jubal.
He was the father of all who grasp harp and flute.
But Zillah, even she bore Tubal Cain,
sharpening all works of brass and iron.
And the sister of Tubal Cain, Naamah.

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Contextual Background

- Humans were to serve God with needs provided
- Banished and made to provide own needs
- Forced to wander while providing own needs
- Built a city to avoid wandering and provide needs

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- Different ways of life, all generally considered negative

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Jabal

"dwelling tents and cattle"

- Often thought of as shepherding
- Hebrew > "livestock" as in possessions
- Jabal was the originator of livestock as a business
  - personal gain
  - not caring and protecting animals (as in Genesis 1)
  - not living off creation (Genesis 1 & 3)

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Jubal

"grasping the harp and flute"

- Often wrongly thought of as music, as in praise and worship
- Mentioned in relation to Jabal *("brother")*
  - a connection/relationship should be understood
  - Jabal was business, so was Jubal his brother
- Hebrew > "grasping"
  - not "playing"
  - usually in negative contexts
- Jubal was probably the originator of the business of manufacture and sale of musical instruments

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Tubal Cain

"sharpening brass and iron"

- Not presented as a brother of Jabal & Jubal
  - an unrelated characterization (not a business?)
  - brass and iron were implements of war
- Therefore . . .
  - focused on warfare: self-protection and/or hostility
  - further watching out for self-interests

Lamech's Three Sons

- Further development from Cain and his city
- Further providing for one's own needs
- Further protecting self against others

- Note:
  - Not to be understood as condemning occupations
  - Must be understood in context of what develops from Cain
    - more independence in self-preservation
    - more independence in providing one's own needs

And Lamech said to his wives, Adah and Zillah

"Hear my voice, wives of Lamech.
Give ear to my speech.
For a man I killed for my wound,
and a youth for my hurt.
If sevenfold will be avenged for Cain,
to Lamech seventy and seven."

Lamech's Poem

- Important: It is ***Lamech's*** perspective
  - He has killed a boy
  - He claims justification
    - He killed because he was injured
  - He compares himself to Cain
    - Cain's protection = 7 times (completion)
    - Lamech's protection = 70x7 (infinite completion)
- Now . . .
  - Humans decide morality *(independent assessment)*
  - Humans decide what God's perspective is

Back to Adam & Eve

- The story begins and ends with Adam & Eve
- Begins and ends with hope for future life in children
- But what changes with them in view of the Cain saga?

And Adam again knew his wife.
And she bore a son.
And she called his name Seth
"For God has set to me a seed in place of Abel,
for Cain killed him."
Now, to Seth, even he bore a son.
And he called his name Enosh.
Then it began, to call on the name of the Lord.

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Now the man knew Eve, his wife.
And she became pregnant.
And she bore Cain.
And she said:
"I have created a man with the Lord."

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Narrator Statement

- Begins with “the man” but ends with “Adam” (a named person)
  - This is the first time *adam* is a name.
  - The man now becomes a person, taking prominence
- Begins with “Eve” but ends with no named person
  - Begins with “the mother of all living”
  - Ends with “his wife”
  - The woman now is featured as Adam’s helper

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*"**I have created** **a man** **with the Lord**."*

Eve's Perspective

- Difference #1 – Name
  - "Cain"
    - related to the verb "create"
    - emphasis on what she has done
  - Seth
    - related to the verb "set" (God set)
    - emphasis on what God has done
- Difference #2 – Subject of the verb (who is acting)
  - God vs "I"
- Difference #3 – "a man" vs. "a seed"
  - Begins with a focus on a replacement man
  - Ends with a focus on the promised "seed of the woman" *(Gen 3:15)*

Lesson Learned!

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And she bore a son.
And she called his name Seth
"For God has set to me a seed in place of Abel,
for Cain killed him."
Now, to Seth, even he bore a son.
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Then it began, to call on the name of the Lord.

The Ending

- Enosh > Hebrew word for a man in his weakness
- Calling on the name of the Lord (Yahweh)
  - Active approach to God
  - No longer approaching God with a gift
  - Rather, simply calling on the Lord in recognized weakness
- The episode that focus on life through one's own efforts, ends with simply calling out to the Lord.